‘play a part on the world stage, even on the narrowest plane of material power, and I should like India to play that great part in that plane’. [142]

Over the years, Indian leaders have lived by Nehru’s belief that ‘India has the right to lead because of her heritage, and also because of her present, when, in the face of the complexity of her own problems, she has stood up and estimated values and not let go all those ideals which she had placed before her’.[143]

Nehru’s personality and charisma ensured that the basic tenets of India’s foreign policy remained unchanged for over five decades.[144] Now Modi hopes to build on his own popularity and charisma for a similar lasting legacy. Nehru’s impact resulted in defining the underlying principle of India’s foreign policy as a desire for independence of action and autonomy of decision making. The belief that India, a great civilization, will one day be a great power has meant that not only has India sought a seat at the global high table but has been unwilling to allow the big powers of the day to dictate to India.